

Psalm 3

A Morning Shield

Lord, how are they increased that trouble me!

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 LORD, how are they increased that trouble me! many are they that rise up against me.
- 2 Many there be which say of my soul, There is no help for him in God. Selah.
- 3 But thou, O LORD, art a shield for me; my glory, and the lifter up of mine head.
- 4 I cried unto the LORD with my voice, and he heard me out of his holy hill. Selah.
- 5 I laid me down and slept; I awaked; for the LORD sustained me.
- 6 I will not be afraid of ten thousands of people, that have set themselves against me round about.
- 7 Arise, O LORD; save me, O my God: for thou hast smitten all mine enemies upon the cheek bone; thou hast broken the teeth of the ungodly.
- 8 Salvation belongeth unto the LORD: thy blessing is upon thy people. Selah.

2 · CONTEXT

Superscription (in the Hebrew Bible tradition): a psalm of David when he fled from Absalom. Psalm 3 is a personal lament that becomes confidence—often called a morning psalm because of verse 5 (sleep and waking). Henry notes the psalmist’s crisis is multiplied enemies and taunts that God will not help; faith answers with God as shield and sustainer. It follows the royal confidence of Psalm 2 with a king under siege.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

Complaint: enemies increase; many rise up; mockers say there is no help in God. The pain is social and spiritual—isolation plus blasphemous taunt. Selah invites a pause under the weight of the crisis.

Verse 3-4

Turning point: “But thou, O Lord, art a shield for me; my glory, and the lifter up of mine head.” Prayer is vocal and answered from God’s holy hill. Protection, dignity, and restoration of courage meet in one confession.

Verse 5-6

Evidence of trust: he sleeps and wakes because the Lord sustains him. Fear of “ten thousands” is refused—not by denial of danger, but by confidence in God’s sustaining presence.

Verse 7-8

Petition and praise: arise, save; God has already struck the ungodly’s power (“broken the teeth”). Salvation belongs to the Lord; blessing rests on His people. Personal deliverance expands to corporate hope.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

When opposition multiplies and voices deny God’s help, faith looks away from the count of enemies to the character of God—shield, glory, head-lifter, sustainer. Sleep becomes a theological act. Salvation is the Lord’s gift, not self-rescue.

Application for life today.

Anxiety often multiplies at night and in isolation. Practice Psalm 3’s pattern: name the trouble honestly, then preach God as shield to your own soul. Ask where mockery (“God won’t help”) has entered your thinking. Entrust sleep and waking to the Sustainer; refuse to let enemy-counts set your fear level.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What “increased” troubles or voices currently say there is “no help... in God” for you?

2. How have you experienced God as shield, glory, or lifter of your head—or where do you need that now?

3. What would trusting the Lord with your sleep and waking look like this week?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).